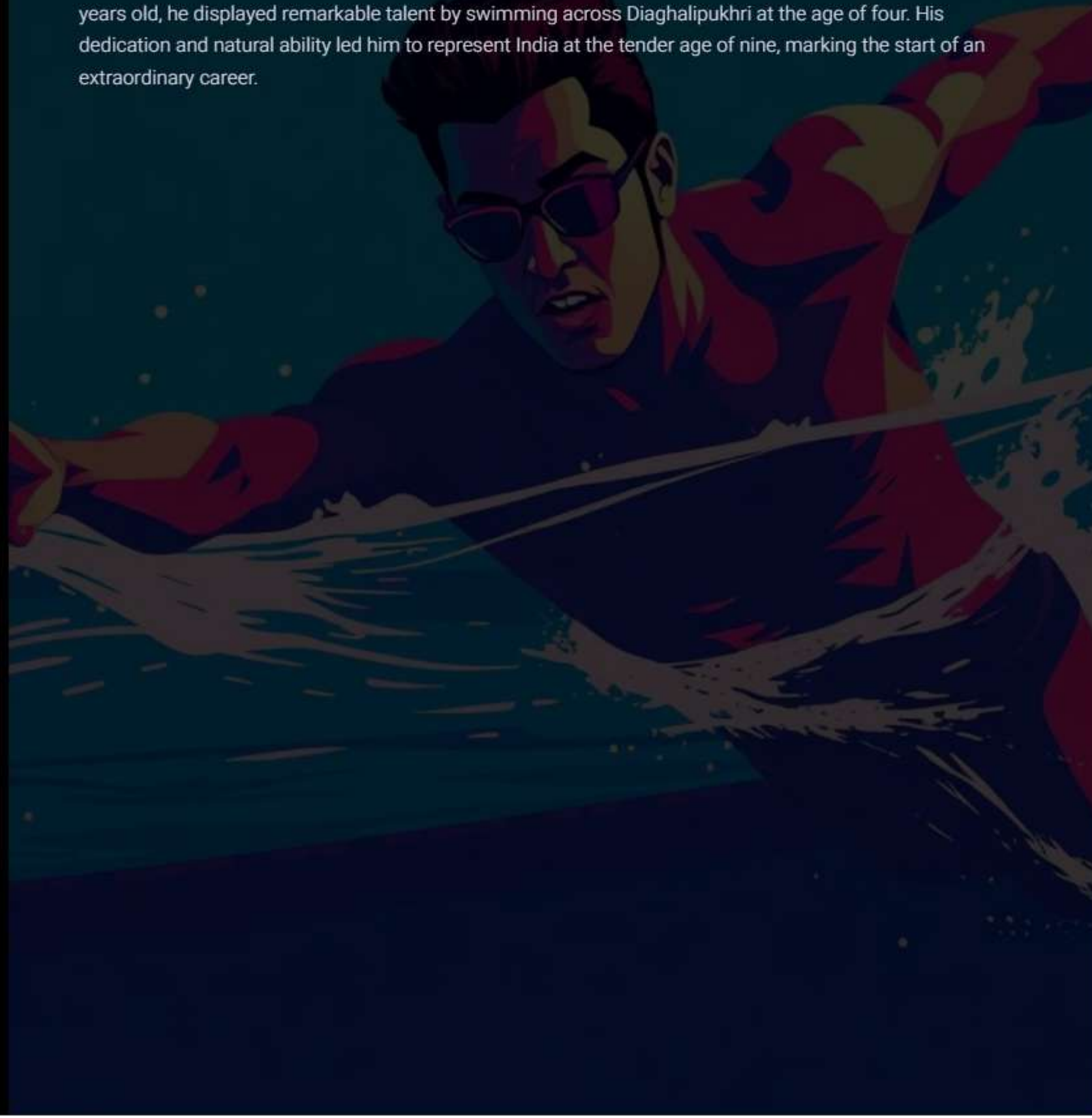


Elvis Ali Hazarika: India's Aquatic Pioneer

Elvis Ali Hazarika, born in Guwahati, Assam, is a renowned long-distance and open-water swimmer who has brought immense pride to both Assam and India. Beginning his swimming journey at just one and a half years old, he displayed remarkable talent by swimming across Diaghalipukhri at the age of four. His dedication and natural ability led him to represent India at the tender age of nine, marking the start of an extraordinary career.



A Legacy of Aquatic Excellence

23

National Records

Set across various swimming disciplines, showcasing his consistent dominance.

68

Total Medals

A testament to his competitive spirit and unwavering performance.

20

International Medals

Achieved on the global stage, bringing honour to his nation.

Conquering the World's Toughest Waters

Elvis is the first Assamese swimmer to conquer several of the world's most challenging open waters, demonstrating unparalleled endurance and courage.



Catalina Channel

USA



North Channel

Northern Ireland & Scotland



English Channel

Both Ways



Baltic Sea

Europe



Robben Island

South Africa



Arabian Sea

Asia

He also completed a historic 12-hour continuous swim in the mighty Brahmaputra River, a feat that inspired countless youths in Assam to pursue their dreams.

Inspiring a Generation



Global Sports Map

Placed Assam and Northeast India prominently on the international sports stage.



Motivating Athletes

Encouraged young athletes to embrace swimming as a path to excellence.



Conservation Advocate

The Next Frontier: Antarctica

Currently, Elvis Ali Hazarika is rigorously preparing for the ultimate challenge: the **Antarctica Ice Mile Swim**. He aims to be the first Indian to achieve this extreme feat, pushing the boundaries of human endurance in one of the world's harshest environments.



A Tryst with Table Tennis

"Monalisa was the first table tennis player in India to have won National Championship in all the three categories i.e. Sub Junior, Junior, and Senior. Monalisa represented India in two World Championships in the Years 1985 and 1987."

Monalisa Barua Mehta, recipient of the prestigious **Acharya Award**, is one of the most famous Assamese Athletes in the field of Table Tennis. Initially, Monalisa started playing in the junior level as a member of the Assam State Junior Team. She won almost all the Zonal championships, and encouragement from her parents also helped her endeavour.

A Champion's Journey: Key Milestones

01

1976: First Major Win
Won her National Sub Junior Championship, marking her arrival on the national stage.

02

1979: National Junior Champion
Achieved the title of National Junior Champion, showcasing her growing dominance.

03

1980: Junior Champion Again
Repeated her performance, securing the National Junior Championship for a second time.

04

1985: Pinnacle of Success
Won the National Championship at Bhopal, becoming the first Indian table tennis player to win national titles in Sub Junior, Junior, and Senior categories.

Representing India on the Global Stage

Monalisa's talent extended beyond national borders, as she proudly represented India in numerous international competitions:

World Championships
Represented India in two World Championships in 1985 and 1987.

Asian & Commonwealth Games
Participated in the sixth Asian Championship, two Asian Games, and two Commonwealth Games.

US Opens & Asian Cup
Competed in two US Opens and three Asian Cup Competitions, showcasing her international presence.

Transition to Coaching: Nurturing Future Talent

After her retirement from active sports, Monalisa dedicated her expertise to nurturing the next generation of Indian table tennis players. She was involved as a coach with the India Junior Table Tennis Team, accompanying them to various international meets:

2004: World Pro Circuit
Accompanied the junior team to Vancouver, Canada.

2006: World Junior Championship
Attended the fourth World Junior Table Tennis Championship in Cairo.

2006: International Pro Circuit
Guided the team at Taiyuan, China.

World Junior Invitation
Coached the team at the World Junior Invitation Tournament in Las Vegas.

Monalisa Barua Mehta: A Legacy of Excellence

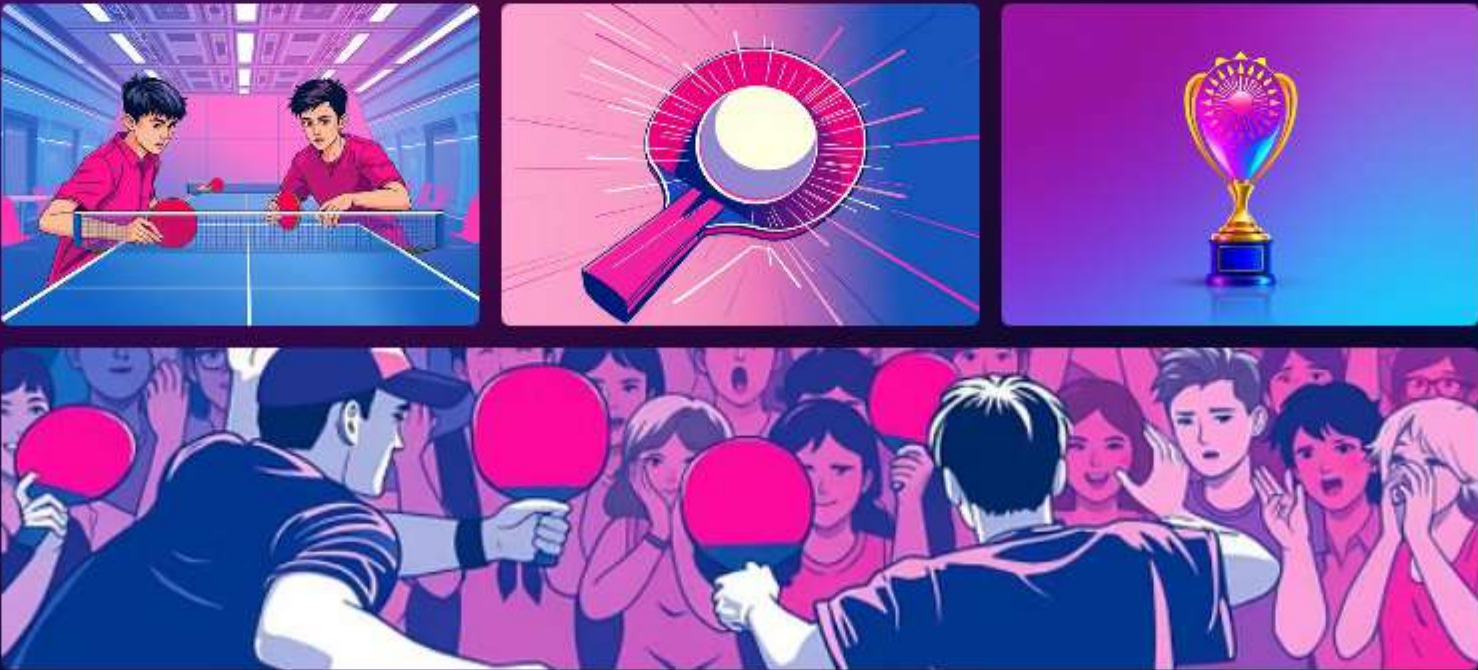
Monalisa Barua Mehta's journey from a promising junior player to a national champion and then a dedicated coach exemplifies a profound commitment to table tennis. Her contributions have not only elevated the sport in India but also inspired countless aspiring athletes.

Impact and Achievements at a Glance

3	2	10+	20+
National Titles	World Championships	International Events	Years of Dedication
First Indian player to win National Championships in Sub Junior, Junior, and Senior categories.	Represented India on the global stage in two prestigious World Championships.	Participated in numerous international competitions, including Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, and US Opens.	Decades of commitment as a player and coach, shaping the future of Indian table tennis.

Inspiring the Next Generation

Her dedication to coaching after retirement further cemented her legacy, guiding young talents to international success. Monalisa Barua Mehta remains a beacon of perseverance and excellence in Indian sports.



"True champions are not just defined by their victories, but by the lives they touch and the inspiration they leave behind."

Bhaona: A Timeless Theatrical Tradition

Bhaona is the staging of the Ankiya Nat, a unique type of play introduced by the Vaishnavite Saint Sankardeva (1463-1568). It is more than a performance; it's a profound message of devotion, unity, and cultural pride. These religious and moral plays enact captivating stories from revered Hindu epics like the Ramayana, Mahabharata, and the Puranas.

The Essence of Bhaona

Devotion A spiritual journey through storytelling, fostering deep reverence.	Unity Bringing communities together through shared cultural experiences.
Cultural Pride Preserving and celebrating the rich heritage of Assam.	Moral Play Enacting timeless tales with ethical and philosophical lessons.

A key feature of Bhaona is the use of intricate masks (Mukhas) which vividly depict gods, demons, and animals, adding a unique visual dimension to the narrative.

From Namghars to Global Stages

For centuries, Bhaona has been performed in Assam's traditional Namghars. However, its reach has now extended far beyond its origins. A dedicated trio from Assam – Ixup Salnia, Gecimallika Sainia, and Gitimalika Saikia – has championed the English adaptation of Bhaona, enabling it to reach a global audience.



Bhaona: A Global Cultural Bridge

Through its captivating narratives and vibrant artistry, Bhaona continues to transcend geographical and linguistic barriers, fostering understanding and appreciation for Assamese culture worldwide.

Moments from the Global Journey



The dedication of artists and cultural enthusiasts ensures that this ancient art form continues to inspire and connect people across continents, proving that art truly knows no bounds.

The Silk Soul of Assam

Assam's silk industry is a vital part of the state's cultural heritage, craftsmanship, and economy, producing three world-renowned varieties – Muga, Eri and Pat. The weaving of Assamese silk, particularly Muga, remains the cradle of tradition, with artisans preserving intricate designs and weaving techniques for generations. Sualkuchi, often called the "Manchester of the East," remains the centre of this handloom culture.



Muga Silk

Known as the golden silk, Muga is exclusive to Assam and highly valued for its natural luster and exceptional durability, making it a prized possession.



Eri Silk

A soft and breathable silk, Eri is cruelty-free as it is harvested without harming the silkworm, making it popular among sustainability-conscious consumers.



Pat Silk

Pat silk is renowned for its smooth texture and elegant drape, often used for traditional Assamese garments like Mekhela Chador and other ceremonial attire.

Current Challenges

- Limited global branding and market reach.
- Climate change threatening silkworm habitats and production.
- Stiff competition from cheaper synthetic textiles.
- Financial insecurity and lack of modern infrastructure for weavers.

Emerging Opportunities

- Rising global demand for sustainable and artisanal fabrics.
- Eco-friendly nature of Assamese silks aligns with market trends.
- Digital platforms and e-commerce for enhanced global visibility.
- Expansion into luxury fashion, home décor, and accessories markets.

Despite its strengths, the industry faces challenges such as limited global branding, climate change threatening silkworm habitats, stiff competition from synthetic textiles and financial insecurity among weavers. However, the rising global demand for sustainable, artisanal fabrics presents a great opportunity.



Government Support

Implementing fair wages, providing training, and offering export incentives to empower artisans and ensure sustainable livelihoods.



Modernisation & Authenticity

Modernising production techniques without compromising the traditional craftsmanship and unique cultural identity of Assamese silk.



Global Partnerships

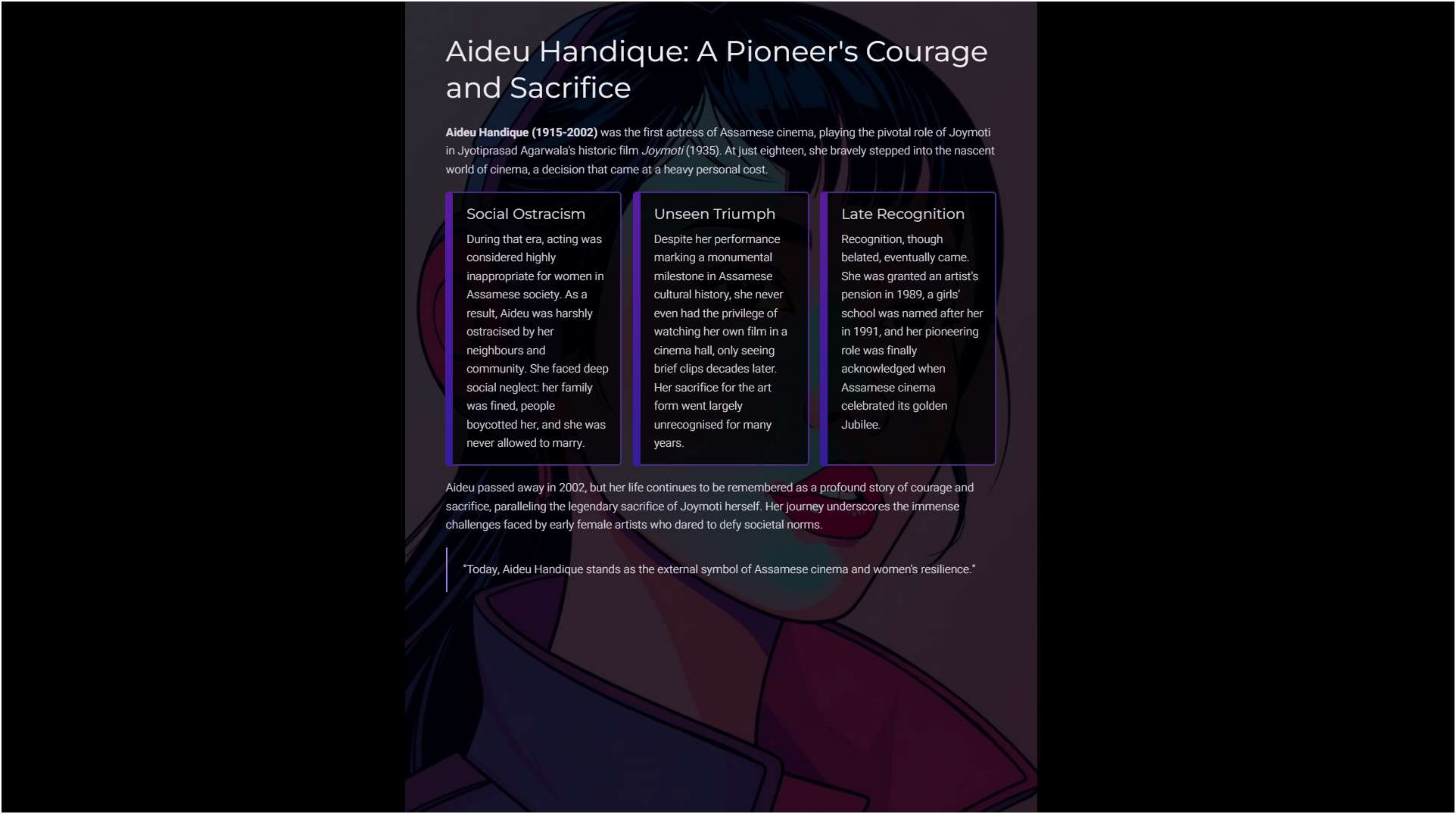
Forging collaborations from heritage roots to modern markets, elevating Assam's silk as a globally celebrated symbol of tradition and sustainability.

For sustainable growth, the industry needs government support through fair wages, training, and export incentives while modernizing production without losing authenticity. By strengthening branding, improving infrastructure, and empowering artisans, forging partnerships from heritage roots to modern markets, Assam's silk can evolve as a globally celebrated symbol of tradition and sustainability.

A Future Woven in Gold

Assam's golden silk, a testament to timeless tradition and sustainable practices, is poised to captivate the world, weaving a future of prosperity and cultural pride.





Aideu Handique: A Pioneer's Courage and Sacrifice

Aideu Handique (1915-2002) was the first actress of Assamese cinema, playing the pivotal role of Joymoti in Jyotiprasad Agarwala's historic film *Joymoti* (1935). At just eighteen, she bravely stepped into the nascent world of cinema, a decision that came at a heavy personal cost.

Social Ostracism

During that era, acting was considered highly inappropriate for women in Assamese society. As a result, Aideu was harshly ostracised by her neighbours and community. She faced deep social neglect: her family was fined, people boycotted her, and she was never allowed to marry.

Unseen Triumph

Despite her performance marking a monumental milestone in Assamese cultural history, she never even had the privilege of watching her own film in a cinema hall, only seeing brief clips decades later. Her sacrifice for the art form went largely unrecognised for many years.

Late Recognition

Recognition, though belated, eventually came. She was granted an artist's pension in 1989, a girls' school was named after her in 1991, and her pioneering role was finally acknowledged when Assamese cinema celebrated its golden Jubilee.

Aideu passed away in 2002, but her life continues to be remembered as a profound story of courage and sacrifice, paralleling the legendary sacrifice of Joymoti herself. Her journey underscores the immense challenges faced by early female artists who dared to defy societal norms.

"Today, Aideu Handique stands as the external symbol of Assamese cinema and women's resilience."

The Enduring Legacy of Pioneering Women in Arts

Aideu Handique's story is a powerful testament to the enduring impact of pioneering women who, against immense odds, forge new paths in the arts. Their courage not only shapes cultural landscapes but also inspires future generations to challenge conventions and pursue their passions.



Breaking Barriers

Pioneers like Aideu Handique shattered societal norms, paving the way for women to participate and excel in fields previously deemed unsuitable for them. Their initial steps, however difficult, created a ripple effect of change.



Inspiring Generations

The sacrifices and triumphs of these early artists serve as a beacon of inspiration. Their narratives encourage contemporary women to embrace their artistic voices and contribute to the rich tapestry of global culture.



Shaping Cultural Identity

Through their groundbreaking work, these women played a crucial role in defining and enriching national and regional cultural identities. Their contributions are foundational to the artistic heritage we cherish today.



Catalysing Evolution

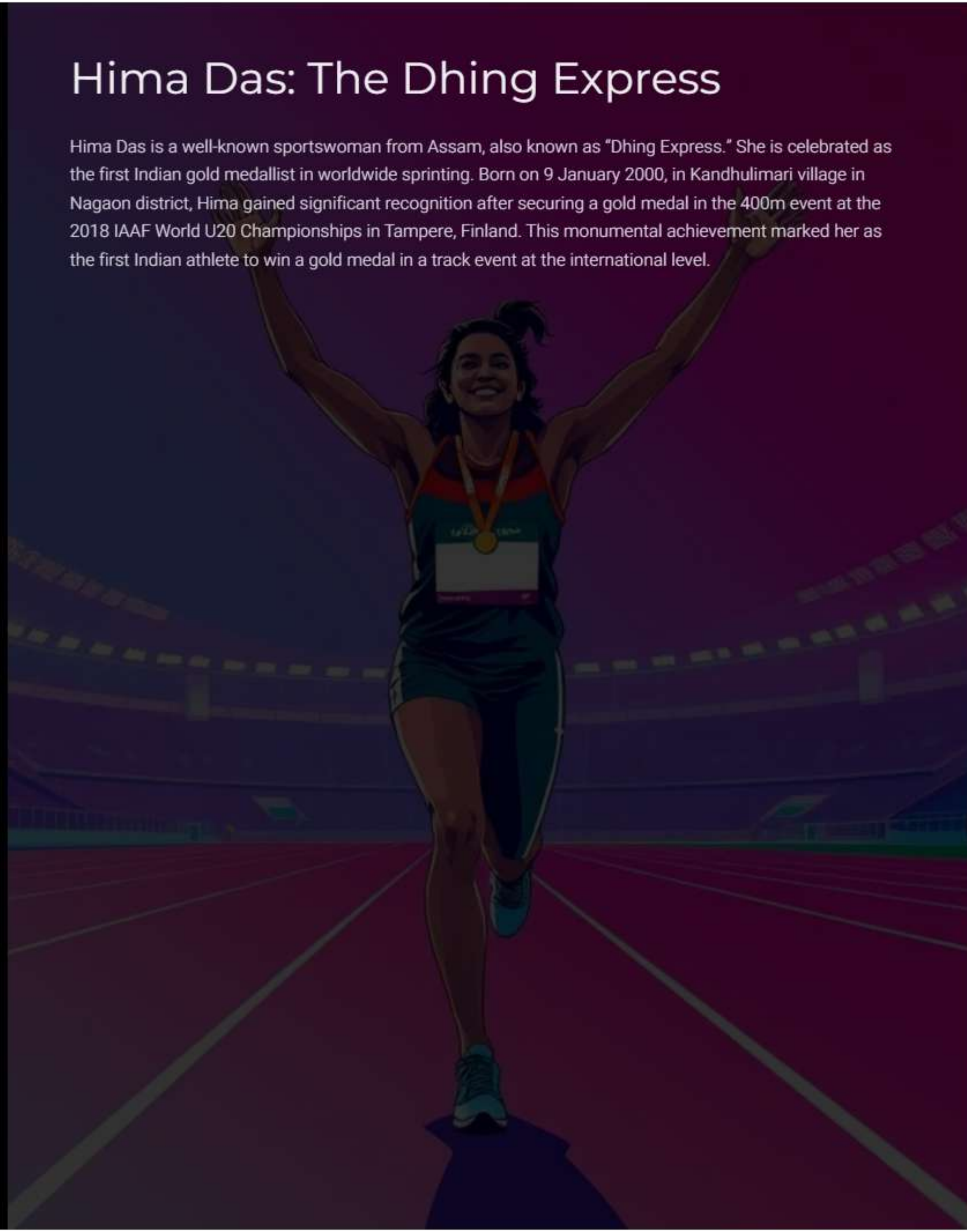
Their entry into new artistic domains often catalysed significant evolution within those fields, pushing boundaries of expression and technique. Cinema, in particular, owes much to its early, brave participants.

The legacy of women like Aideu Handique extends far beyond their individual achievements. It is a collective narrative of resilience, artistic integrity, and the relentless pursuit of creative freedom, ensuring that their contributions continue to resonate and empower.



Hima Das: The Dhing Express

Hima Das is a well-known sportswoman from Assam, also known as "Dhing Express." She is celebrated as the first Indian gold medallist in worldwide sprinting. Born on 9 January 2000, in Kandhulimari village in Nagaon district, Hima gained significant recognition after securing a gold medal in the 400m event at the 2018 IAAF World U20 Championships in Tampere, Finland. This monumental achievement marked her as the first Indian athlete to win a gold medal in a track event at the international level.



The Remarkable Journey of Hima Das

Hima was born into a humble agricultural family and initially harboured aspirations of pursuing football. Her path took a pivotal turn when her physical education teacher, Shamsul Haque, encouraged her to delve into athletics under the expert guidance of coach Nipon Das. It was under this mentorship that Hima's innate talent truly flourished, leading her to compete and excel at both state and national levels.



Milestones and Accolades



Inspiring a Generation



Empowering Girls in Sport

Hima Das has become a powerful role model, inspiring countless young girls to pursue their dreams in sports and break societal barriers.



Profound Impact on Youth

Her journey from a small village to international fame has had a significant and positive impact on the youth, encouraging perseverance and ambition.

Mamoni (Roisom) Goswami: A Literary and Peacemaking Icon

Indira (Mamoni Roisom) Goswami was a renowned Assamese writer, celebrated for her profound contributions to literature and her unwavering commitment to peace. Her work transcended linguistic barriers, earning her international acclaim and a lasting legacy.

Literary Prowess

Goswami gained significant recognition in 1982 for her novel *Mamore Dhora Taruwal*. Many of her works, including novels and short stories, have been translated into several Indian and foreign languages, and are included in university curricula worldwide.

Scholarly Contributions

Her research focus was primarily on the *Ramayana*, a field in which she was widely respected for her insightful contributions. Her academic rigour complemented her creative output, showcasing her multifaceted intellect.

Peace Activism

Apart from writing, she dedicated herself to peace efforts, notably bringing youth groups and the government to the negotiation table in Assam. Her courageous mediation efforts earned her international recognition.

Accolades and Recognition

Mamoni Goswami's exceptional talent and dedication were recognised with numerous prestigious awards, solidifying her status as a literary giant and a global advocate for peace.

Assam Sahitya Sabha Award
(1988)



Katha National Award
(1993)

Jnanpith Award
(2000)



Prince Claus Award
(2008)

She was also honoured internationally, receiving the title of " *Changgiwon Jeongnang* " in Seoul, a testament to her global impact beyond the literary world.

Blending Life and Literature

Her autobiography *Adha Lekha Dastabez* and some of her other writings like *Tez aru Dhulir xahid*, and *Dotal Hatir une khowa Howda*, blend personal experiences with history, showcasing her remarkable courage and honesty. She remains a shining star in Assamese literature.

Her Enduring Impact and Inspiration

A Voice for the Voiceless, A Bridge for Peace.

Mamoni (Roisom) Goswami's influence extends far beyond her written words. She embodied the power of an individual to drive change, foster understanding, and inspire generations. Her legacy is a vibrant tapestry woven from literary brilliance, academic dedication, and profound humanitarianism.



Literary Excellence

Her narratives continue to captivate and educate readers worldwide, exploring complex themes with unparalleled depth and sensitivity.



Advocate for Harmony

Her tireless efforts fostered dialogue and reconciliation, proving that peace is achievable through persistent and compassionate engagement.



Academic Influence

Her scholarly work enriches university curricula and research, providing invaluable insights into the Ramayana and Indian culture.



Guiding Light

An inspiration for future generations of writers, scholars, and activists, her life serves as a beacon of courage and integrity.

"Her life and work stand as a testament to the power of literature and compassion in shaping a better world."

Mamoni (Roisom) Goswami's legacy transcends borders, reminding us of the profound impact one individual can have on society through art and action. Her spirit continues to illuminate the path towards a more understanding and peaceful future.

Dr. Bhupen Hazarika

Dr. Bhupen Hazarika was a legendary Indian singer, composer, lyricist, and filmmaker from Assam. He was deeply rooted in the rich cultural heritage of the Brahmaputra Valley. Born on September 8, 1926, in Sadiya, Assam, known as the **"Bard of the Brahmaputra,"** Dr. Hazarika's music reflected the beauty and struggles of the region, as well as the universal themes of humanity and social justice.

With a career spanning over six decades, he sang and composed songs in multiple languages, including Assamese, Bengali, Hindi, and English. Dr. Hazarika's contributions to music and cinema earned him numerous accolades, including:

National Film Award

Recognised for his outstanding contributions to Indian cinema.

Padma Shri

One of India's highest civilian awards, bestowed for his artistic excellence.

Padma Bhushan

Further national recognition for his distinguished service in the arts.

Padma Vibhushan

Awarded posthumously, acknowledging his exceptional and distinguished service.

Bharat Ratna

India's highest civilian award, conferred posthumously, cementing his status as a national treasure.

Through his work, Dr. Hazarika represented not only Assamese culture but also the rich cultural diversity of India. His legacy continues to inspire and influence artists and audiences alike, with his music remaining a testament to his enduring talent and vision.

The Enduring Legacy of Dr. Bhupen Hazarika

Dr. Bhupen Hazarika's impact extended far beyond the realm of music; he was a cultural phenomenon who used his art to bridge divides and champion the cause of the common person. His unique blend of traditional Assamese folk melodies with Western influences created a distinctive sound that resonated globally.



Cultural Ambassador

He introduced Assamese culture to a global audience, fostering understanding and appreciation.



Voice of the People

His songs often addressed social injustice, poverty, and human rights, making him a powerful advocate.



Musical Innovator

He pioneered a unique fusion of folk, classical, and contemporary music, inspiring new genres.



Inspiration for Generations

His philosophy and artistic integrity continue to guide and motivate artists across India and beyond.

His multilingual compositions were a testament to his belief in unity through diversity. He effortlessly transitioned between languages, ensuring his message of peace and harmony reached a wider audience.



Assamese

His native tongue, the heart of his folk and traditional compositions.



Bengali

Composed numerous popular songs, deeply loved in West Bengal and Bangladesh.



Hindi

Contributed significantly to Bollywood, with memorable film scores and songs.



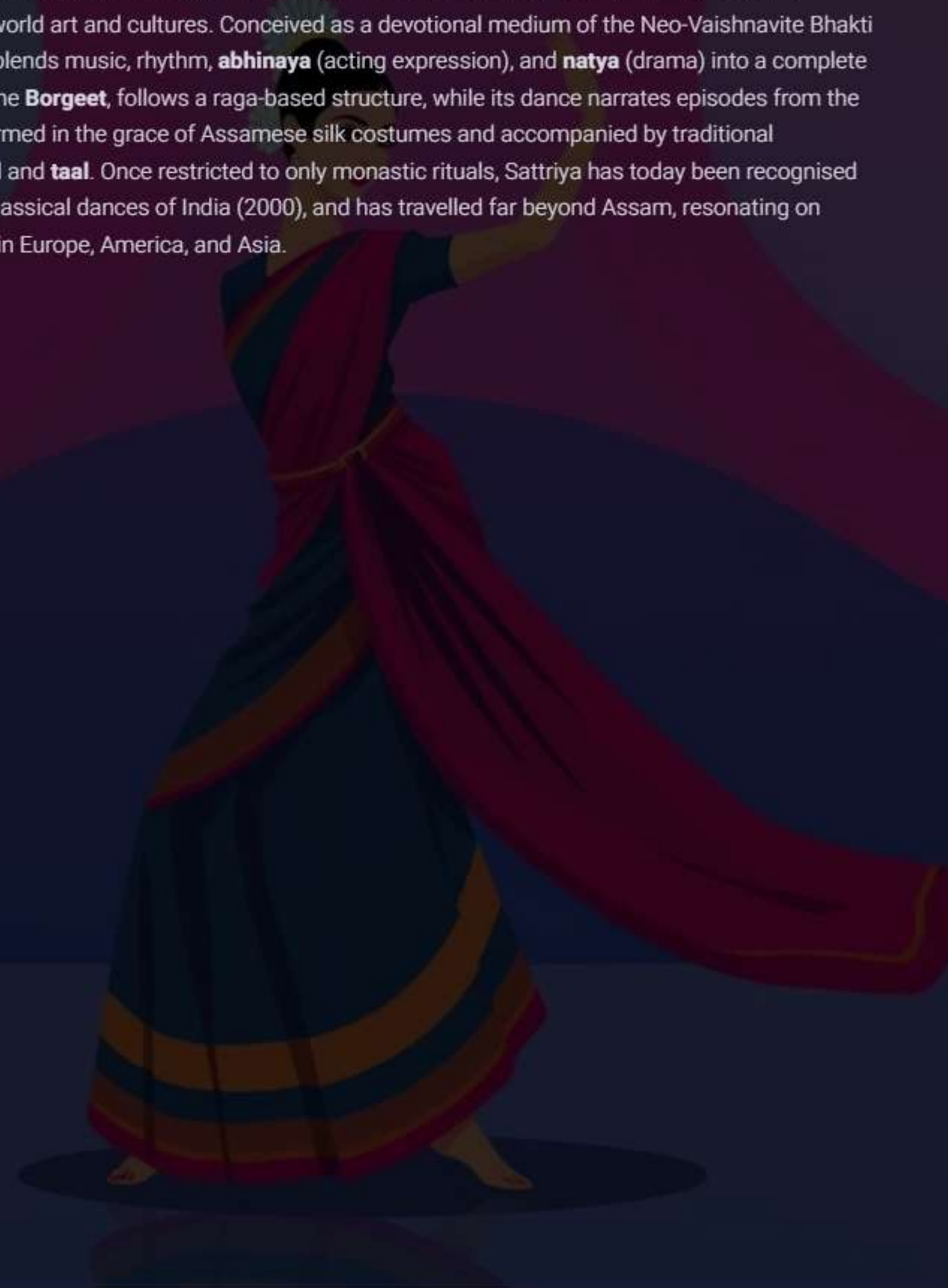
English

Penned and performed songs in English, reaching international listeners.

Dr. Hazarika's vision of a harmonious society, articulated through his powerful lyrics and soulful melodies, remains as relevant today as it was during his lifetime. He truly was a *'Bard of the Brahmaputra'* whose voice transcended geographical and linguistic boundaries, leaving an indelible mark on the cultural landscape of India and the world.

From the Monasteries to the Stage: The Journey of Sattriya Nritya

Sattriya Nritya (dance), born in the **satras** (Vaishnavite monasteries) in the 15th-16th century through the vision of Srimanta Sankardeva, has transcended the confines of Assam's Satras to find a voice in the universal chorus of world art and cultures. Conceived as a devotional medium of the Neo-Vaishnavite Bhakti movement, Sattriya blends music, rhythm, **abhinaya** (acting expression), and **natya** (drama) into a complete art form. Its music, the **Borgeet**, follows a raga-based structure, while its dance narrates episodes from the life of Krishna, performed in the grace of Assamese silk costumes and accompanied by traditional instruments like **khol** and **taal**. Once restricted to only monastic rituals, Sattriya has today been recognised as one of the eight classical dances of India (2000), and has travelled far beyond Assam, resonating on international stages in Europe, America, and Asia.



Sattriya Nritya: Global Recognition and Visionary Exponents

Several eminent exponents have played a vital role in introducing Sattriya dance to international stages.



Guru Jatin Goswami

Instrumental in popularising Sattriya dance worldwide and helping it gain recognition as a classical dance of India in 2000. He performed and conducted workshops in Europe, the U.S., and other countries.



Indira PP Bora

Performed extensively abroad, showcasing the elegance of this art form.



Anwesa Mahanta

A younger exponent who has carried Sattriya to cultural platforms in the U.S., U.K., Japan, and other countries.



Prateesh Suresh

Contributed through captivating performances that highlighted the intricate beauty of Sattriya Nritya.



Guru Ghanakanta Bora

Instrumental in both performing and teaching, preserving and disseminating the traditional techniques and spiritual essence of the dance form.

Their dedication helped Sattriya Nritya transcend Assam's Satras to reach the world stage, fostering cross-cultural understanding and appreciation for India's rich artistic heritage.